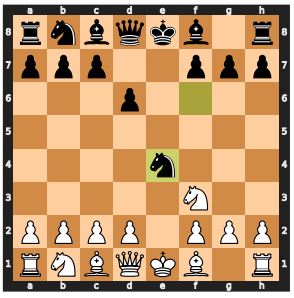
Game 10



Petroff Defence

Capablanca – Marshall

St. Petersburg, 1914

White: J. R. Capablanca Black: F. J. Marshall

Notes by J. R. Capablanca, from Chess Fundamentals *(1921), which is in the public domain.*
Descriptive notation has been converted to algebraic. Page references are to the book.
Click any move or diagram to open it on Lichess.

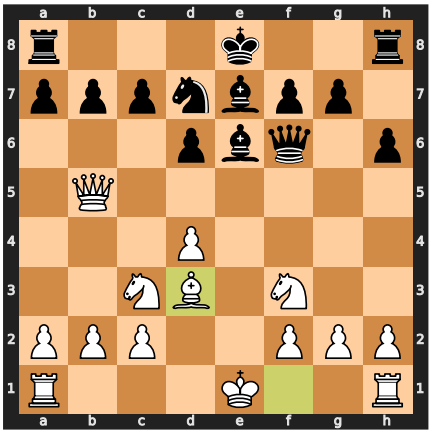
1.e4 e5 2.♘f3 ♘f6 3.♘xe5 d6 4.♘f3 ♘xe4 5.♕e2 ♕e7 6.d3 ♘f6 7.♗g5

Played by Morphy, and a very fine move. The point is that should Black exchange Queens he will be a move behind in development and consequently will get a cramped game if White plays accurately.

7...♗e6

Marshall thought at the time that this was the best move and consequently played it in preference to 7...♕xe2+.

8.♘c3 h6 9.♗xf6 ♕xf6 10.d4 ♗e7 11.♕b5+ ♘d7 12.♗d3!



It is now time to examine the result of the opening. On White's side we find the minor pieces well posted and the Queen out in a somewhat odd place, it is true, but safe from attack and actually attacking a Pawn. White is also ready to Castle. White's position is evidently free from danger and his pieces can easily manoeuvre.

On Black's side the first thing we notice is that he has retained both his Bishops, unquestionably an advantage; but on the other hand we find his pieces bunched together too much, and the Queen in danger of being attacked without having any good square to go to. The Bishop at e7 has no freedom and it blocks the Queen, which, in its turn, blocks the Bishop. Besides, Black cannot Castle on the King's side (12...0–0) because 13.♕xb7 ♖ab8 14.♕e4 threatening mate, wins a Pawn. Nor can he Castle on the Queen's side (12...0–0–0) because 13.♕a5 would put Black's game in imminent danger, since he cannot play ...a6 because of ♗xa6; nor can he play ♔b8 because of ♘b5. Consequently we must conclude that the opening is all in White's favour.

12...g5

To make room for his Queen, threatening also ...g4.

13.h3 0–0

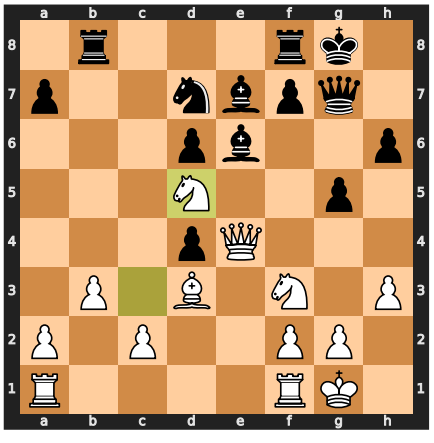
giving up a Pawn in an attempt to free his game and take the initiative. It was difficult for him to find a move, as White threatened ♘e4, and should Black go with the Queen to g7, then d5, ♗f5; ♘xg5+, followed by ♗xf5.

14.♕xb7 ♖ab8 15.♕e4 ♕g7 16.b3 c5

In order to break up White's centre and bring his Knight to c5 and thus lay the foundation for a violent attack against White's King. The plan, however, fails, as it always must in such cases, because Black's development is backward, and consequently his pieces are not properly placed.

17.0–0 cxd4 18.♘d5!

A simple move, which destroys Black's plan utterly. Black will now have no concerted action of his pieces, and, as his Pawns are all weak, he will sooner or later lose them.



18...♗d8 19.♗c4 ♘c5 20.♕xd4 ♕xd4

The fact that he has to exchange Queens when he is a Pawn behind shows that Black's game is lost.

21.♘xd4 ♗xd5 22.♗xd5 ♗f6 23.♖ad1 ♗xd4

The Knight was too threatening. But now the ending brought about is one in which the Bishop is stronger than the Knight; which makes Black's plight a desperate one. The game has no further interest, and it is only because of its value as a study of this variation of the Petroff that I have given it. Black was able to fight it out until the sixtieth move on account of some poor play on White's part. The rest of the moves are given merely as a matter of form.

24.♖xd4 ♔g7 25.♗c4 ♖b6 26.♖e1 ♔f6 27.f4 ♘e6 28.fxg5+ hxg5 29.♖f1+ ♔e7 30.♖g4 ♖g8 31.♖f5 ♖c6 32.h4 ♖gc8 33.hxg5 ♖c5 34.♗xe6 fxe6 35.♖xc5 ♖xc5 36.g6 ♔f8 37.♖c4 ♖a5 38.a4 ♔g7 39.♖c6 ♖d5 40.♖c7+ ♔xg6 41.♖xa7 ♖d1+ 42.♔h2 d5 43.a5 ♖c1 44.♖c7 ♖a1 45.b4 ♖a4 46.c3 d4 47.♖c6 dxc3 48.♖xc3 ♖xb4 49.♖a3 ♖b7 50.a6 ♖a7 51.♖a5 ♔f6 52.g4 ♔e7 53.♔g3 ♔d6 54.♔f4 ♔c7 55.♔e5 ♔d7 56.g5 ♔e7 57.g6 ♔f8 58.♔xe6 ♔e8 59.g7 ♖xg7 60.a7 ♖g6+ 61.♔f5
Resigns.